Standard Email Reply Templates

Three messages cover most of what an inbox needs, and each one fits on a screen without scrolling.

Answer in the first sentence — no "I hope this finds you well." · **One question per message**, at most. · **Say the date**, not "soon". · **Sign as the client's assistant** when sending from their address.

1. ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Use when something arrives that needs work you cannot finish in two minutes, and the sender would otherwise wonder if it landed.

```
Subject: Re: [their subject] — received, looking into it
```

> Hi [Name],
>
> Got this — thanks for sending it through.
>
> I'm looking into [the specific thing] now and will come back to you by
> [day, date] with [what they will receive: an answer, a quote, the file].
>
> If anything changes before then, reply here and I'll pick it up.
>
> [Signature]

2. FOLLOW-UP

Use when a `02-Waiting` item has passed its expected date, or a request has gone quiet for a week.

```
Subject: Re: [their subject] — checking in
```

> Hi [Name],
>
> Following up on [the thing] — I sent it on [date] and haven't heard back,
> so I want to make sure it didn't get buried.
>
> Is there anything you need from me to move it forward? If the timing has
> changed, just tell me the new date and I'll update my side.
>
> [Signature]

Why it works — it assumes the message was buried rather than ignored, which is almost always true, and it lets the recipient answer without apologising.

3. DELAY NOTICE

Use when you will miss a date you committed to. Send it *before* the deadline, never after.

```
Subject: [Project] — small delay, new date [date]
```

> Hi [Name],
>
> I'm going to miss [the original date] on [the thing]. The reason is
> [one line, factual, no excuses].
>
> New date: [day, date]. What you'll have then: [the deliverable, specifically].
>
> If that date causes a problem on your side, tell me today and I'll tell
> you what can be ready sooner instead.
>
> [Signature]

What not to write — "I've been really busy", "just wanted to touch base", or an apology longer than the explanation. A delay notice is judged on whether the new date holds.

Tone check. Read it as the recipient; if it does not say what happens next, it is not finished.